Parshas Shlach

Fear, Leadership, and Bringing Kedusha Into the World

Meraglim · Grapes · Leadership · Engaging the World

I. Sent Out, Coming Back

This week in Eretz Yisrael we read Parshas Shlach, the story of the meraglim. And I have to start with something personal, because this week it felt unusually close.

Last week I mentioned that I had a business trip to Chutz La'Aretz. Somebody sent me to Chutz La'Aretz, as opposed to the meraglim we will speak about shortly, who were sent into Eretz Yisrael. Before leaving, I had that conversation with Rav Channen and some chevra about tucking in the tzitzis, hiding the payos, how to carry myself as a frum Jew in the business world. Not in yeshiva. Not surrounded by Torah. Out in the world, representing something. Baruch Hashem, I think I did pretty well. I was able to speak truth and maintain Torah values in a place where there was not so much Torah taking place. That is always a good opportunity and a real responsibility, and it ties into what we speak about so often, being an or la'amim, a light unto the nations. We stand firm in our beliefs and value systems without being obnoxious about it.

And then there was the story at the airport coming home. I was finally at the gate, surrounded by the El Al area, basically a sea of Jews, and I said to myself: I can take out the tzitzis now. I did not take out the payos because my hair was a bit of a mess. I was doing some work on my laptop, having a call with the kids, and then someone saw the tzitzis and said to me: "Achi, bo iti, ani chaver moadon" — "Brother, come with me, I have a lounge membership." This was not a Shomer Shabbos Jew. Not a Shomer Mitzvos Jew. But he saw a fellow Jew because the tzitzis were out, and that was enough. The value, the opportunity, and the timing were something.

We sat down, there was some very enjoyable kosher food, and we had a real conversation. Business, yes, but also Torah, the value of Eretz Yisrael, what it means to live in a makom of kedusha. To hear from someone whose mitzvah observance is not where it could be, someone we would call a tinok shenishba, raised without these priorities, and yet whose hargasha, whose emotional connection to Eretz Yisrael and to fellow Jews and to Hashem was completely real and present. I know I speak often about how feelings alone are not sufficient. We have Torah, Shulchan Aruch, the poskim. But his awareness, his ability to

sit and genuinely listen, that dialogue was beautiful. Be'ezras Hashem, I hope to stay in touch with him. It helped pass the final hour before boarding beautifully. And it is exactly the kind of thing this week's parsha is about.

II. Shlach Lecha: Permission, Not Command

The parsha opens:

שְׁלַח לְךָ אֲנָשִׁים

"Send for yourself men."

— Bamidbar 13:2

Rashi explains that the word lecha, for yourself, signals permission rather than command. Hashem is saying: if you want to do this, you may. The initiative came from the people. They were nervous about what lay ahead and they wanted to send scouts to see the land first. And Hashem permitted it. Which already tells us something. Hashem did not say this was a good idea. He said you have permission. Hindsight is twenty-twenty for us sitting here reading the story. But they were living through it in real time, in the middle of the desert, with all the uncertainty that came with that. The decision to send the meraglim did not come from nowhere. It came from a people who were still carrying something heavy inside them.

III. A Question at a Shalom Zachor

This brings me to a question a friend asked me at a Shalom Zachor recently. He asked why the entire dor hamidbar deserved to be punished for what the meraglim did. It is a real question. Why hold the whole nation responsible?

I want to use a mashal from politics, and I am not going to get into any particular side here. But we all know the dynamic. People back whoever they voted for, whoever represents their side. Sometimes they are not even voting for someone so much as against someone else. And then afterward, if the other side does something wrong, they say, see, I was right. But if their own leader does something wrong, many people will still defend that leader, because admitting the leader was wrong would mean admitting that they themselves may have made a mistake. And people have a very hard time doing that. In life, in careers, in politics, in learning. Admitting you were wrong is genuinely difficult.

If we look at the story of the meraglim through Rashi's lens, the people sent their chosen leaders on this mission. The meraglim were not random. They were gedolei Yisrael, the heads of the shevatim. And when those leaders came back with a frightening report, the

nation accepted it. Not because there was no alternative. Yehoshua and Kalev were standing right there. Yehoshua had received a special bracha from Moshe before leaving. Kalev had gone to daven at Me'aras HaMachpelah for the strength to resist the others. Both of them had been mevateil themselves to the true purpose of the mission. And yet Klal Yisrael did not listen to them. They could have said: if these two are disagreeing, maybe we should pause. They could have remembered everything Hashem had already done for them. But they did not. And that is why they bore responsibility. Not because they were the ones who spoke, but because they had the tools to push back respectfully and chose not to use them.

IV. Lies Embedded in Truth

The meraglim were not simply lying. That is what makes this story so much harder than it looks. They embedded their distortion inside real truth. They came back with actual fruits of the land, enormous grapes, visible proof of the incredible abundance of Eretz Yisrael. And then they said: "Look at the size of these fruits. Imagine the size of the people who grew them. We cannot overcome them."

The same evidence that should have inspired emunah became a tool for despair. The very thing meant to demonstrate how amazing Eretz Yisrael is got flipped into a reason to be afraid. That is a specific kind of distortion, and it is one of the most dangerous ones, because it is hard to argue against. The facts are real. Only the conclusion is wrong.

Think about the grapes in particular. Grapes represent wine. Wine is Kiddush, simcha, nisuch hayayin, avodah. The Nazir cannot even come near grapes because of their level of kedusha. When approached in a healthy and aligned way, grapes represent some of the highest forms of holiness and connection to Hashem available in the physical world. The meraglim took something that was a symbol of kedusha and transformed it into an argument for fear. They took what was meant to be the most inspiring thing about the land and turned it into the most frightening. That is the tragedy.

V. What the Meraglim Actually Wanted

The mefarshim explain something important about the meraglim's motivation that changes how we read the whole story. They were not simply cowards. They were not simply liars. They wanted to stay in the Midbar. They knew what had happened in Mitzrayim, how a people had been absorbed slowly into a culture until they almost lost themselves entirely. They had seen it. They were afraid of the same thing happening in

Eretz Yisrael. The physical world, the land, the farming, the wars, the engagement with the nations around them, all of it felt like a threat to the kedusha they had found in the desert under the Ananei HaKavod with the mann falling every morning.

That concern was not entirely wrong. The danger of spiritual absorption into the physical world is real. But they missed the entire point of the mission. The goal was never to protect Klal Yisrael from the world by keeping them in the desert forever. The goal was to bring Klal Yisrael into the world and teach them how to elevate it. They took a partially correct concern and used it to block the very thing Hashem wanted. And Rav Gerzi teaches often that this is a reflection of the slave mentality Klal Yisrael still carried at that point. They had left Mitzrayim physically but had not yet fully left it internally. The next generation, born in the desert, raised with a different frame of reference, would be the ones who could actually make the crossing.

VI. They Got the Order Backwards

And then comes what is perhaps the most heartbreaking part of the whole parsha. After the decree comes down, after Hashem tells them that this generation will not enter Eretz Yisrael, a group rises up and says: no. We will go anyway. We will go into Eretz Yisrael right now. And Moshe Rabbeinu stands before them and tells them not to go. Hashem is not with this. This is not the time. Do not do this.

They went anyway. And many were lost.

The same people who listened when they should have pushed back now pushed forward when they should have listened. They got the order exactly backwards. This is a real and serious lesson. Not every act of passion is healthy. Not every attempt at teshuvah is aligned. Even a genuine desire to correct a mistake requires being inside the right framework. Doing the right thing at the wrong time, in the wrong way, without proper guidance, is still wrong. Pirkei Avos says aseh lecha rav, make for yourself a teacher. That is not just about having someone to answer halachic questions. It means having someone who helps you know when to speak and when to listen, when to push and when to wait. Yehoshua and Kalev had that. They were mevateil themselves to the ratzon Hashem and to the guidance they had received. The nation, twice over, did not.

VII. After the Shift: Challah, Wine, and Karbanos

And yet the parsha does not end there. After all the tragedy, after the decree and the failed attempt to reverse it, the parsha shifts. Suddenly we are in the halachos of karbanos, of

challah, of wine libations, of the framework for how Klal Yisrael will engage the physical world once they enter the land.

Why here? Why now?

Because the Torah is showing us what healthy engagement looks like. Once the generation that cannot enter has been accounted for, the focus turns toward the generation that will enter. And what does their life in Eretz Yisrael look like? Bread becomes holy through challah. Wine becomes holy through nisuch hayayin and Kiddush. The physical acts of farming and eating and celebrating become avodos Hashem through the framework Hashem gives us. That is what it means to live in Eretz Yisrael. Not to escape the physical world, but to elevate it.

Rabbi Yehoshua Gordon, zichrono livrachah, used to explain this with a beautiful mashal. If your wife says to you, "If you love me, bring me flowers," then the flowers become an expression of love. The act itself becomes the vehicle. The karbanos work the same way. The ma'aseh matters because it aligns with the ratzon Hashem. The physical action done with the right kavana and within the right framework becomes something holy. That is the goal of entering Eretz Yisrael. That is the goal of living in this world.

VIII. Or La'Amim, Here and Now

Even today, living in Eretz Yisrael, we are still in a form of galus. The Beis HaMikdash is not rebuilt. The Sanhedrin is not restored. But we can imagine what geulah looks like. We can live in a way that moves toward it rather than away from it. The meraglim had partially correct concerns, but they forgot the purpose of creation itself. We are supposed to be in this world. We are supposed to engage it, elevate it, bring kedusha into it through the framework Hashem gave us.

That man at the airport lounge, the one who spotted my tzitzis and said achi, bo iti, he was a small proof of that. He was not where he could be in terms of observance. But something inside him responded. The light was visible. And that one hour of conversation, over some good kosher food in a London airport, was exactly the kind of thing the meraglim were afraid of and the Torah was always pointing toward. Not hiding from the world. Being present in it. Carrying the kedusha of who we are into the spaces we actually move through. And knowing the how, the why, the where, and most importantly, the when.

Because sometimes doing the right thing at the wrong time is still wrong. And sometimes the most meaningful thing we can do is simply show up, tzitzis out, and let someone say, 'Achi.'

חזק ואחזק

Good Shabbos

Reflection Questions

- *Where in my life am I embedding distortion inside real truth, taking something genuine and tilting it just enough to justify fear or avoidance?*
- *Is there a place where I am defending a position not because I still believe it fully, but because admitting the mistake feels too painful? What would honest reckoning with that look like?*
- *Am I more like the meraglim who refused to enter, or the group who rushed in without guidance? Which extreme pulls at me more, and what does healthy balance look like?*
- *Where in my life do I have a Yehoshua or Kalev standing in front of me, someone offering a different perspective that I am not fully listening to?*
- *What does it look like for me to engage the physical world, my work, my relationships, my daily life, in a way that elevates it rather than either fleeing from it or being absorbed by it?*
- *Am I being an or la'amim in the actual spaces I move through every day? Not through performance, but through the steady visible presence of who I am?*